



ROCKET FUEL  
FACTORY

# Doing More Without Adding Bodies

Global Sync Meetup NYC, 17 September 2026

Tim Fournet | Rewst

[therocketfuelfactory.com](https://therocketfuelfactory.com)

SLIDE 1 OF 21

TARGET 0:00.

- One sentence of thanks to Dawn and Dave, then go.

WHERE WE ARE

# Whose vacation request do you dread approving?



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## SLIDE 2 OF 21

TARGET 0:20. SLOW.

- You have a name in your head right now.
- You are not afraid because they are lazy, or because the team is thin.
- You are afraid because when they are out, things go wrong that nobody can explain, and the client is the one who notices.
- Keep that name. This talk is about that person.
- It is about why the work they do has never made it out of their head.

WHAT THEY DECIDE ALL DAY

**Which alert is noise.**  
**Which client wants the details.**  
**Which ticket gets a phone call.**

**Those are decisions, and they are not in any document.**

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3

## SLIDE 3 OF 21

TARGET 1:00. SLOW.

- Here is a piece of what that person carries.
- Take the alert that fires every night at two. They know it clears itself.
- They also know the one that looks identical and does not.
- That is a decision, and it is not in any document. Nobody has asked them for it, including you.
- That is why the hire does not fix it. A new person cannot learn what nobody has written down.
- In six months you have two people you cannot spare instead of one.
- That is why the vacation request scares you, and it is not their fault.
- Here is how it got that way.

# Handing over the work is not the same as delegating

| WHEN YOU DELEGATE                                                                                                                                                                                                               | WHEN YOU HAND OVER THE RULES TOO                                                                                                                                                         |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• You hand them the queue.</li><li>• You wrote the rule down: call on any P1, and on anything from a client who has called twice.</li><li>• They check the ticket against that.</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• You hand them the queue.</li><li>• You left the rule to them: use your judgment.</li><li>• They guess, and with luck they guess right.</li></ul> |

Your best employees are the ones who usually guess right.

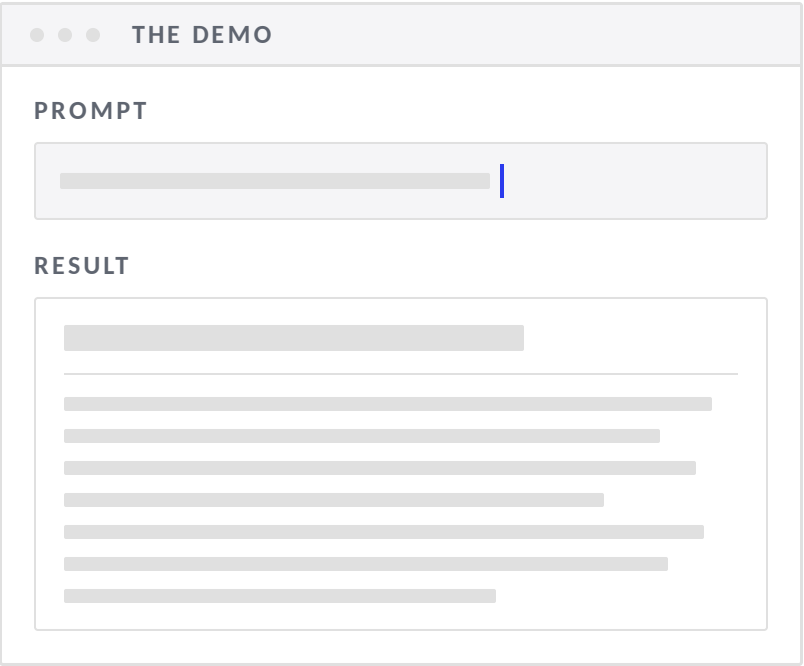
SLIDE 4 OF 21

TARGET 2:30.

- You hand a job to your senior tech with about two sentences, and it comes back right.
- So you assume the two sentences were good. They were not.
- That person made a dozen small calls you never mentioned, and made them the way you would have.
- Give the same two sentences to somebody new. It comes back wrong, and you decide the new person is not working out.
- The brief was the problem both times.
- Left column: the rule for who gets a phone call took one sentence. Nobody in your company has ever been asked for it.
- We have been paying for the guess instead. We cover for our own communication with their guesswork.
- **PIVOT: If highly trained humans fail when we expect them to follow unwritten rules, what happens when we do the same with AI?**

# We expect AI to do wonders with a little instruction

- AI demos give a little instruction and show something beautiful built from it.
- Beautiful does not mean the details are where you want them.
- You already know what a junior tech does with a ticket that thin: real effort, a reasonable guess, and something you would not put your name on.
- AI does that too, without the pause where a person asks you a question.



## SLIDE 5 OF 21

TARGET 4:00.

- I have sat through a lot of these demos. Somebody types a sentence, something gorgeous appears.
- Nobody checks whether the details are right, because in a demo nobody has to.
- Watch one carefully and the presenter does not stop at one sentence either. They come back with more instructions. That part gets cut short.
- So I go back to work and try it the same way: one sentence and a paste.
- What comes back is real effort and a reasonable guess, and I would not send it.
- Here is what that looks like.

# How most people prompt

Write an email to the client about this. Apologize and let them know we're on top of it.

 <pasted from the PSA>

**Ticket #48213 - Harbor Dental - Dentrix down all sites**

Status: Resolved      Priority: P1      Opened: 09/12 08:47 by Dana W (client)  
Contact: Dana Whitfield, Office Mgr      Board: Service Desk      Type: Network / Outage

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 08:47 - Dana called, front desk at Midtown and Riverside can't open Dentrix, main office is fine. Users getting "cannot connect to database server." She's pretty upset, says they have a full waiting room. Told her we're looking. | 08:52 - Tunnels from Midtown and Riverside to HQ FGT-60F are down. Phase 1 failing. Cert on the FGT expired 09/11 23:59. This is the same cert we flagged in the Q2 review that nobody approved the renewal on. | 09:10 - Regenerated CSR, submitted to DigiCert. Waiting on issuance.<br><br>09:48 - Cert issued. Installed on FGT-60F, rebound to IPsec Phase 1. |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

SLIDE 6 OF 21

TARGET 4:40.

- This is how most of us do it. One line, and paste the ticket under it.
- The ticket has everything a tech would need: the full waiting room, the FortiGate, Phase 1, DigiCert.
- And that line near the bottom about the Q2 review, where nobody approved the renewal.
- My best tech reads that and knows what to leave out.
- The AI has no idea who Dana is.

# What the client would have received

FROM

Alex

TO

Dana Whitfield

**Subject: Resolved – Dentrix Outage at Midtown & Riverside (Ticket #48213)**

Hi Dana,

I want to sincerely apologize for the disruption this morning at your Midtown and Riverside offices. I know a full waiting room with no access to Dentrix is incredibly stressful for your team and your patients, and I'm sorry we didn't catch this before it caused an issue.

**What happened:** A security certificate on your main office firewall expired overnight, which broke the secure network connection between HQ and the two branch offices. This prevented Midtown and Riverside from reaching the Dentrix server — the server itself and your patient data were never at risk or offline at any point.

**What we did:** Our team identified the cause within minutes of your call, issued and installed a renewed certificate, and restored connectivity. Riverside was back online at 10:12 AM and Midtown at 10:15 AM. We confirmed all three sites were fully operational before closing the ticket.

**Total impact:** Approximately 1.5 hours of intermittent access issues at the two branch locations. No data was lost or compromised.

**What we're doing to prevent this going forward:** **This certificate had actually been flagged for renewal in our Q2 review, and we're correcting the gap that let it lapse.** We're adding automated certificate expiration monitoring to our systems so we get advance alerts well before any certificate nears expiration — this will ensure we catch and renew these proactively going forward, rather than reactively.

Thank you for your patience this morning, and please don't hesitate to reach out if you have any questions or if anything seems off at any of the sites.

Best regards,  
Alex  
[Your Company Name] – Service Desk

**It leaked that line in two of three runs, and you had no say in which.**

## SLIDE 7 OF 21

TARGET 5:30.

- Dana opens this. The first thing is that it looks right. Ticket number, headers, the shape of a real incident report.
- Then the blue line.
- That is the one sentence in that ticket I would never put in front of a client. It says we knew, and nobody acted on it.
- And it is now in an email Dana forwards to the dentist who owns the practice.
- I ran this three times. Two of the three had that line.
- I never told it that line was off limits. It had no way to know.

# Ask it how to ask better

YOU

That's not the email I needed, and I don't want you to just take another swing at it. Look at how I asked you. What should I have told you up front so you could have written the one I had in my head? Teach me to ask better, not just to get a better email this once.

THE MODEL

Fair. Here's what was missing, concretely:

- 1. Who's actually reading it, and what's their relationship to the incident
- 2. What "on top of it" was supposed to mean, specifically
- 3. Whether the Q2-review detail was a feature or a liability
- 4. Tone register
- 5. Whether there's a business ask riding along

Every one of those is a rule you already had in your head.

SLIDE 8 OF 21

TARGET 6:30.

- Here is what worked. We did not type try again, and we did not fix the email ourselves.
- We asked it what we should have told it in the first place.
- It gave us five things: who is reading, what on top of it meant, whether the Q2 detail was a feature or a liability, what tone, whether there was a business ask.
- We knew the answer to every one of those before we typed a word. We just never wrote them down.
- And it owned the leak. It called the Q2 sentence the riskiest line in the ticket, and admitted it made that call for us without asking.
- It knew it was guessing. It will tell you, if you ask.
- Try this tonight on the last answer that disappointed you.

# The same ask, with the rules written down

I need to send Dana Whitfield an email about this morning's outage. She's the office manager at Harbor Dental, three locations, and she's the one the front desk complains to. **She isn't technical and doesn't want to be. She'll forward whatever I send straight to Dr. Patel,** who owns the practice, so it has to stand on its own with no editing.

The ticket notes are below, but **don't quote them.** She doesn't need the equipment names or the timeline, and **she definitely doesn't need to hear that we flagged this cert in the spring and the renewal never got approved.** That's a conversation for me and Dr. Patel, not this email. What she needs to know is that all three offices were down together for about 90 minutes, why in one plain sentence, that everyone was back by 10:25, and that no patient data was touched, because **that's what she asked me on the phone and what she's afraid of.**

The part I actually care about is what comes next. We're adding monitoring that warns us thirty days before any certificate expires, and it'll be in place by Friday. **That's what "on top of it" actually means, so say that. Do not use the phrase "on top of it" anywhere in the email.**

Keep it under 150 words, plain language. Own it without groveling. **Sign it from me, Alex at Northline IT.**

 Ticket #48213 - Harbor Dental - Dentrix down all sites

SAME TICKET PASTED BELOW >

SLIDE 9 OF 21

TARGET 8:10.

- Same ticket, pasted underneath again. This is what went above it this time.
- Everything in blue is an answer to one of the five questions.
- Who Dana is, and that she forwards whatever we send to Dr. Patel, who owns the practice.
- Do not quote the ticket. She does not need to hear that we flagged this cert in the spring and nobody approved the renewal.
- No patient data was touched, because that is what she asked on the phone.
- What on top of it actually means: monitoring in place by Friday.
- That is the rule written down. This is delegating.

# A draft you can put your name on

TO

Dana Whitfield

SUBJECT

**This Morning's Outage — Resolved**

Dana,

This morning's Dentrux outage at all three offices was caused by a network security certificate on our end that expired overnight. It's a straightforward fix once identified, but it did knock all three locations offline together, starting around 8:47 AM. Riverside and Midtown were back up by 10:15, and we had all three sites fully verified by 10:25 — about 90 minutes total.

No patient data was affected. The server itself was never down or at risk; the offices simply couldn't reach it while the connection was out.

We're putting in place monitoring that will alert us 30 days before any certificate is set to expire, so this specific failure mode can't catch us again. That'll be live by Friday.

Sorry for the disruption to your morning — I know a full waiting room makes this worse. Let me know if you have any questions.

Alex  
Northline IT

Send

Those five questions work on any brief, to a person or a machine.

SLIDE 10 OF 21

TARGET 9:20.

- Under 150 words. It names the dentist. Nothing in it that Dana should not see.
- Same tool, same ticket. The only thing we changed was what we told it.
- Now the part that matters. The machine never talked to Dana.
- I read this, I put my name on it, and I sent it. The draft is its job. The send is mine.
- Those five questions are not about email. They work on a person too.
- When we say we set up new users, what we have is a ticket with the facts, and the rules are in someone's head.
- You just saw what happens when we hand that to something that cannot guess.

AHARON'S FIRST LAW OF AUTOMATION

# You can't automate a process that doesn't exist.



Aharon Chernin, Rewst

## SLIDE 11 OF 21

TARGET 10:40. SLOW.

- We built computers to be automation machines, and most of us are afraid to actually automate anything with them. I think this is why.
- Aharon Chernin, who I work with, puts it this way: you can't automate a process that doesn't exist.
- I have been quoting that for years, and it means something different to me every time.
- Today it means this. Having a process is not the same as having someone who knows how it is done.
- Most of what we call a process is the second thing.
- The first time you try to automate it, you find out which one you have, because the machine cannot ask what you meant.
- That is worth an afternoon even if nothing ships.
- Here is the same thing happening to a checklist instead of an email.

WHAT THE LAW MEANS HERE

# A client's employee leaves while Mike is on vacation

CHECKLIST: EMPLOYEE DEPARTURE

OWNER

COMPLETED

Mike

6 of 6

☒ Disable the account

☒ Forward the mailbox

☒ Collect the laptop

☒ **Cancel software licenses**

☒ Remove from distribution lists

☒ Close the ticket

THAT LINE MEANS

To Chris, covering for Mike

**Microsoft 365**

To Mike

**Microsoft 365, Adobe, and the two tools he set up for that client**

ADOBE INVOICE, TWELVE MONTHS LATER

Adobe Creative Cloud

**9 seats**

A step is only documented if someone else can follow it without asking for help.

SLIDE 12 OF 21

TARGET 11:10.

- A client calls: one of their people is leaving on Friday. We have a checklist for that. Six steps, and everyone follows it.
- Mike wrote it, and Mike is on vacation this week. So Chris covers.
- One line says cancel software licenses. Chris cancels Microsoft 365, ticks the box, closes the ticket. Nothing looks wrong.
- A year later you reconcile the Adobe bill and find nine seats for people who no longer work there.
- Nobody skipped a step. To Mike that line means Microsoft, Adobe, and the two tools he set up for that client. To Chris it means Microsoft.
- This is the email again. On top of it meant something in one head and nothing anywhere else.
- What it costs: Mike cannot take a vacation. Every departure gets handled twice. And the hire that covers for Mike is insurance, not capacity.
- The test I use: a step is only documented if someone else can follow it without asking for help. Not word count, not screenshots. Whether Chris has to turn his chair around and ask.
- The fix for that line is an hour with Mike. The problem is that it is one line on one list, and Mike owns forty lists like it.
- That is what doing more without adding bodies means: fewer people needed to make a process safe.

# I keep seeing MSPs try to automate the wrong side of operations

| WHAT IS SOLD TO ANSWER THE CUSTOMER                             |   | WHAT WE ARE ACTUALLY BUYING                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------|---|----------------------------------------------|
| An agent that answers the support line and opens the ticket.    | → | A phone that does not ring.                  |
| An agent in the client's Teams, first message to closed ticket. | → | A ticket that closes without a conversation. |
| Password resets with no tech involved.                          | → | An end user we never have to talk to.        |
| The quarterly review generated from the data.                   | → | A review meeting we do not have to sit in.   |

Automate to give time back to the customer, not to hide from them.

SLIDE 13 OF 21

TARGET 13:10.

- So the process is written down. Where do we point the machine? Here is what I keep seeing.
- Left column is what is being sold to MSPs right now, and sold hard: an agent on the phone, an agent in the client's Teams, password resets nobody touches, a quarterly review that writes itself.
- Right column is what I think we are actually buying. A phone that does not ring. A ticket that closes without a conversation.
- If I am honest, I think we buy these because deep down a lot of us do not like talking to customers, or we are a little afraid to.
- Every one of those sounds like relief, and I get it. Here is the problem.
- The call you did not take is the call where you would have heard that Dana is shopping for a new MSP.
- The review meeting you skipped is where the next thing you sell them gets sold.
- Those conversations are the only part of this business a competitor cannot undercut on price.
- I am not saying the tools are bad. I am saying the aim is wrong.
- In the demo, the machine wrote the draft and I made the call to Dana. That split is the whole point.
- Point the machine at our side of the desk, and spend the hours you get back in front of the customer.

TWO MACHINES

# Which machine gets what



SLIDE 14 OF 21

TARGET 15:10.

- The work is written down, so now I pick who does it.
- I have two machines and they are not the same. One follows the rules exactly and the other makes a good guess.
- Next three slides: how I split the work, how I keep the guessing one away from the customer and the record, and what it costs me to check.

# What I hand to each kind of step

|  DETERMINISTIC |  PROBABILISTIC |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Work with an exact rule, if this then that.                                                      | Work where a good guess is enough: drafting, sorting, summarizing.                                |
| It does the same thing every time, so you check it once.                                         | It does something a little different every run, so someone checks every time.                     |
| A gap in the rule shows up as an error.                                                          | A gap in the brief shows up in the answer.                                                        |

You already run a probabilistic system: a tech at 4pm on a Tuesday.

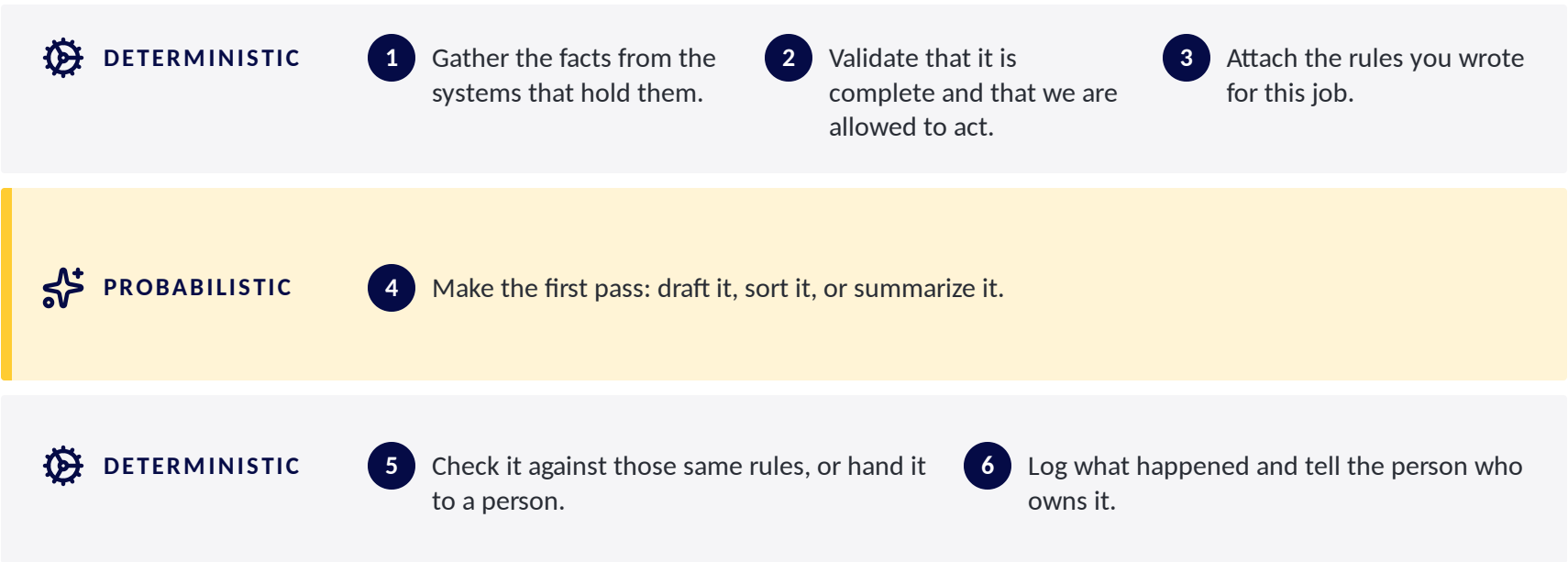
SLIDE 15 OF 21

TARGET 15:40.

- Two words, and then I will stop using jargon.
- Deterministic: same input, same output, every time. Probabilistic: a good answer, and a slightly different one each time you ask.
- The steps we call automation are deterministic. The steps we call AI are probabilistic. Neither is better. A finished automation is built from both.
- Deterministic gets the work with an exact rule. I check it once, sign off, and let it run.
- When it hits something the rule does not cover, it does not improvise. It errors, and I hear about it.
- Probabilistic gets the work where a good guess is enough. Draft the email. Sort the inbox. Summarize the ticket.
- It is a little different every run, so someone reads it every time.
- When the brief has a gap, the gap does not come back as an error. It comes back inside the answer. That Q2 line was a gap in the brief.
- If that sounds like a lot of checking: a tech at 4pm on a Tuesday is a probabilistic system, and you do not ban the tech. You put a second pair of eyes on the work that matters.

THE GUARDRAIL SANDWICH

# You can put AI in the middle of a process you wrote



**Tell it everything in writing before it starts, then check whether it understood.**

SLIDE 16 OF 21

TARGET 17:40.

- So yes, you can use AI inside your operations. This is how I do it, and I call it the guardrail sandwich.
- The whole thing is one automation. The bread is deterministic. The filling is probabilistic.
- Think of it as communication, the same as with a person you hand work to.
- Top slice is everything you tell it before it starts. Gather the facts from the systems that hold them. Validate that we are allowed to act. If either fails, it stops and a person hears about it.
- Then attach the rules you wrote for this job. That is the step I see skipped most often. It is the brief from the demo.
- The filling is the one thing it does: the first pass. Draft, sort, summarize.
- Bottom slice is checking whether it understood you. Check against the same rules. If a rule cannot check it, a person does. Then log it and tell the owner.
- The AI never touches the customer or the record on its own.
- None of this works if the rules are still in somebody's head. That is why everything before this slide was about getting them out.
- If you saw me at Right of Boom, this is the same sandwich with the day to day put in.

THE CHECK

# The check is how you know it understood you

You check the answer against the same rules you wrote for the step, which is why writing them down mattered.

- Decide what a good answer looks like before you build the step.
- Ask for the answer in a shape a rule can test, like a category, a yes or no, or a number.
- Write down what went in, what came out, and who approved it, on every run.

| RUN LOG, THIS MORNING |                                |  |                |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------|--|----------------|
| 09:52                 | Ticket 48213, outage email     |  |                |
| OUT                   | Draft, 138 words               |  |                |
| CHECK                 | Rules passed                   |  | Alex sent      |
| 10:04                 | Ticket 48219, printer          |  |                |
| OUT                   | Category: hardware             |  |                |
| CHECK                 | Rules passed                   |  | Auto           |
| 10:11                 | Ticket 48220, billing question |  |                |
| OUT                   | Draft, 212 words               |  |                |
| CHECK                 | Over 150 words                 |  | Held for Chris |

When a client asks what the AI did with their data, you read them the run.

SLIDE 17 OF 21

TARGET 20:10.

- The machine made its pass. Now I find out whether it understood me, the same way I do with a person. I read the draft against what I asked for.
- If I wrote the rules down, that check is fast. If I did not, the check is me re-deciding the whole job, and I have bought a subscription and kept the work.
- That is the part nobody puts in the demo, and it is the honest limit on all of this.
- Keep the check fast: decide it first, and ask for an answer in a shape something can test. A category. A yes or no. A number under 150.
- Then log the run. What went in, what came out, who signed off.
- Third row: the draft came back at 212 words, the rule said 150, so it went nowhere. It sat there for Chris. Nobody had to read it to catch it.
- This does not move the queue to Chris. It changes it. He only sees the exceptions.
- The log is the record of the conversation, and the only version anyone else can read.
- When a client asks what the AI did with their data, I do not tell them it is fine. I read them the run.
- The harder version of that question is the legal session at 3:15.

THE MORE

## Your customers have the same problem you do

They have a person the process lives in, and a month of work that only that person can do.

- Invoices that get retyped from one system into another.
- Approvals that wait on one manager's inbox.
- A month-end report built by hand from three spreadsheets.

### WHAT YOU GET FOR IT

- Hours you spend in front of them instead of behind a screen.
- A story about your own operations they watched you live.
- A new revenue stream that makes you harder to replace.

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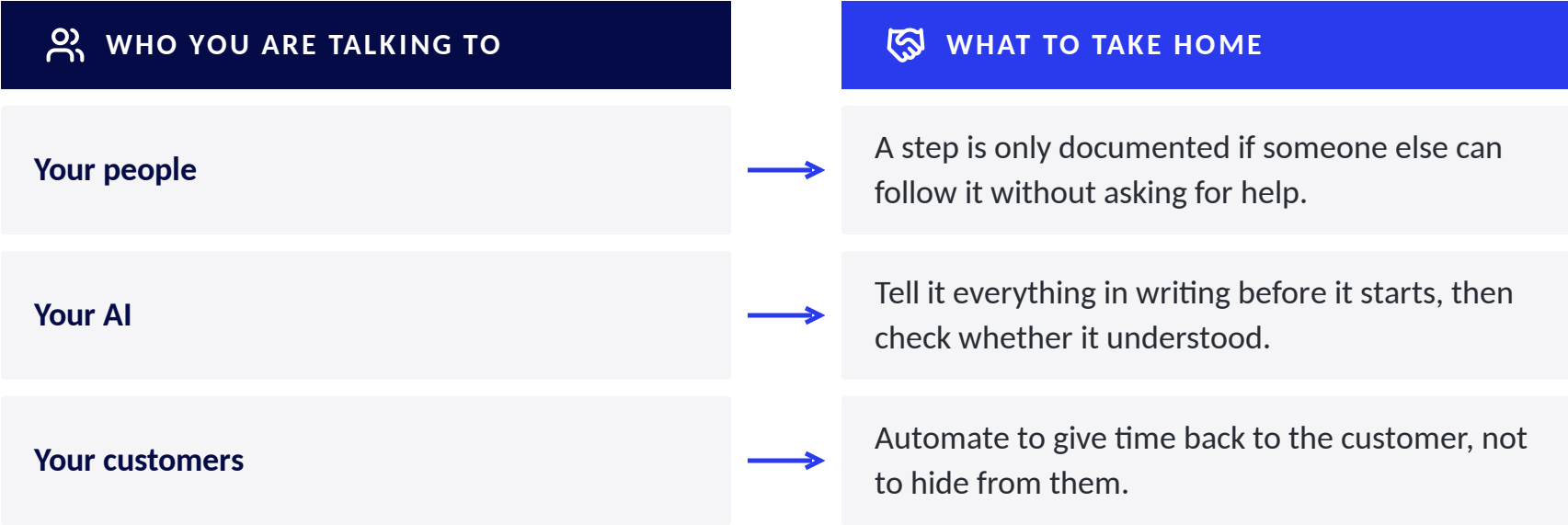
18

### SLIDE 18 OF 21

TARGET 21:40. SLOW.

- This is the more in the title. Everything so far was your own operations. Now look at your clients.
- They have a Mike too.
- Somebody retypes every invoice from one system into another. Somebody waits three days on one manager's inbox. Somebody builds the month-end report by hand and is the only one who knows which numbers go where.
- Nobody in that building has written those steps down.
- You just watched how for twenty minutes: sit with the person, get the rule out of their head, put a machine behind it.
- What you get: the hours you got back, spent in front of them. A story about your own operations that they watched happen. A new revenue stream that makes you harder to replace.
- That is the more. Not fewer people. More of the work only you can do for them.

# Better communication with your people, your AI, and your customers



SLIDE 19 OF 21

TARGET 23:10.

- If you take one picture today, take this one.
- Everything I have said is about three conversations, and they are the same conversation.
- Your people: a step is only documented if someone else can follow it without asking for help. That is Mike's checklist.
- Your AI: tell it everything in writing before it starts, then check whether it understood. That is the email, and the sandwich.
- Your customers: automate to give time back to them, not to hide from them. That is where the hours go.
- We have always had to communicate well with our customers and our people. Now there is a third one, and it needs exactly what the other two always needed from us.



# Sit with one employee you would hate to lose

Ask them what they do at least once a month that they dread. Work out the unwritten process behind it and write it down. Then ask three questions. Could someone else follow it without asking for help? Could some or all of it be automated? Would that person feel threatened by that, or relieved?

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## SLIDE 20 OF 21

TARGET 23:50. SLOW.

- One thing to do this month. Sit with one employee you would hate to lose.
- You already know who. You named them at the start, when I asked whose vacation request you dread.
- Ask what they do at least once a month that they dread. Work out the process behind it, and write it down with them.
- Question one: could someone else follow it without asking for help? If not, you are not done writing.
- Question two: could some or all of it be automated? Even if not, the process exists now, and that person can take a vacation.
- Question three, the one I would sit with longest: would that person feel threatened by that, or relieved?
- If the honest answer is threatened, you have not told them why you are doing this. That is on you, not them. You are doing it so they can take the vacation.
- That is the whole talk in an afternoon, with one person.
- Erik and Atul are up next, with the version of this where the person the process lives in is you.

**PRESENTER**

## Who was that

**Tim Fournet**

Rewst  rewst

Builds automation for MSPs.  
Spent a long time being the  
person the process lived in.

## Rocket Fuel Factory

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21

SLIDE 21 OF 21

**TARGET 25:10.**

- I am Tim Fournet. I build automation at Rewst, and I spent a long time being the person the process lived in.
- Erik and Atul, it is yours.